▶ ODISHA

QUESTIONS IN PRISON, ANSWERS AT LARGE

A recruitment racket blows the lid off Odisha's police exams, revealing criminal syndicates spanning states as well as official collusion

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TAINTED PROCESS Odisha CM Mohan Charan Majhi at a police induction ceremony; (inset) Sankar Prusty, prime suspect in recruitment scam

THREE LUXURY BUSES, 117 ON BOARD, destination Vizianagaram. If not for a tipoff, no one would have noticed. But once the entourage was stopped near the Odisha-Andhra Pradesh border on September 30, the chain of revelations that ensued was truly eye-popping. After day-long interrogation, 114 turned out to be sub-inspector hopefuls, set to write an exam run by the Odisha Police Recruitment Board (OPRB) on October 5-6. The remaining three were middlemen. The whole lot was being ferried to a "special coaching" camp based on leaked question papers. Each aspirant had allegedly agreed to pay Rs 25 lakh in instalments—ten upfront, the rest after bagging the job.

All 117, including the middlemen, were arrested. Once a wider probe began, it became evident that what the Berhampur police had caught that day was one strand of a mammoth recruitment racket: an elaborate operation with organised criminal syndicates operating across states and with footprints running deep into officialdom. This particular scam, which targeted an exam that had attracted over 153,000 applicants for 933 posts, could turn out to be the biggest of its ilk in Odisha's history.

The probe, since taken over by the Odisha Police Crime Branch, has exposed a tangled network of private contractors and sub-contractors trailing out from what should have been a watertight state-run process. The OPRB, a small body with only three members and a handful of staff, had outsourced the technical aspects of the exam to ITI Limited, a central PSU under the telecom ministry. ITI in turn sub-contracted its work to the private firm Silicon Techlab, which then passed on key tasks to another Bhubaneswar-based firm, Panchsoft Technologies. This chain of outsourcing left critical responsibilities in the hands of private entities. Both Silicon Techlab and Panchsoft's offices in Bhubaneswar have since been sealed.

Takeaways

- **Odisha's police recruitment exam scam exposes a nexus of leaks, middlemen and private contractors**
- **Deep official collusion behind rigged selections sparks statewide protests and a political storm**

WEB OF COLLUSION

The prime suspect, Panchsoft promoter Sankar Prusty, has been absconding. The Crime Branch has issued a lookout notice for him and several others while conducting raids in Odisha, Jharkhand and Bihar. Investigators believe Prusty, operating under his wife's name, had previously engaged in similar malpractices with another firm, Kedarnath Technologies. Intelligence reports submitted to the Director General of Police, Y.B. Khurania, had indeed waved a red flag: some senior police officers had been visiting the offices of these private firms frequently. Due diligence, the report warned, was grossly neglected while outsourcing such a sensitive exam.